

League of Legends — primer for researchers

Audience: Charles (and advisors) with FPS / sim background (e.g. Apex, War Thunder), **no MOBA experience**.
Purpose: Enough context to read Alex’s Big Fish panel, talk through a data story, and map LoL esports to the HERO frame (environment ≠ advancement).
Data: `datasets/legends/lol_big_fish_player_split_panel.csv` · column map in `datasets/legends/README.md`

1. What League of Legends is

League of Legends (LoL) is a **5v5 team MOBA** (multiplayer online battle arena). It is **not** a battle royale or vehicle sim.

If you know...	LoL analogue
Apex squad	Fixed 5-player team , fixed roles for the whole match
Match → loot → circle	One map , one objective (destroy the enemy base)
War Thunder BR tiers	Leagues/tiers of pro competition (regional + “major” leagues)
Ranked ladder	Pro circuit: orgs, contracts, promotion between league levels

Each match is roughly **25–45 minutes**. Deaths matter (respawn after a timer), but there is no “next ring” — the win condition is destroying the enemy **Nexus** (home base) after pushing through **lanes** and **towers**.

2. One match in plain English

1. **Two teams of five** spawn on opposite sides of **Summoner’s Rift** (the standard competitive map).
2. Three **lanes** (top, mid, bot) plus **jungle** (the space between lanes). **Minions** spawn and push lanes; players **farm** gold and XP from minions and fights.
3. Each player picks a **champion** (character with unique abilities) and a **role**:

Role (CSV code)	Typical job
top	Bruisers, tanks — isolated side lane
jng (jungle)	Roams the map, secures neutral objectives
mid	Mages, assassins — map center
bot	Ranged damage (“ADC”)
sup (support)	Peel, heal, engage for bot lane

4. Teams fight for **objectives** (towers, dragons, baron) to get stronger and open the map.
 5. First team to destroy the enemy **Nexus** wins.
- Compared to Apex: less about aim and zone pressure, more about **macro** (when to fight, push, rotate), **team composition**, and **role discipline** over one long round.

3. Esports structure (why the CSV has leagues and splits)

Pro LoL is **league-based**, like soccer divisions in different countries — not one global queue.

Regions and top-tier leagues

Examples of **top-tier** regional leagues:

Code	Region
LCK	Korea (historically strongest)
LPL	China (large, deep talent pool)
LEC	Europe
LCS	North America

Each region runs **splits** — sub-seasons within a calendar year (often Spring / Summer; names vary). Teams play a **regular season**, then **playoffs**, then sometimes **international** events (e.g. Worlds).

Teams and rosters

- A **team** (org + brand, e.g. T1, Cloud9) fields a **roster** — typically **one starter per role**, sometimes substitutes.
- Players **transfer** between teams and regions. Alex noted **more roster swapping than college basketball**, which affects how stable a “pond” is across splits.

Developmental (“academy”) leagues — central to our Y

Many orgs run two levels:

Level	Example	Analogy
Top tier	LCK, LPL, LEC, LCS	NBA, MLB
Developmental	LCK Challengers, LDL (China), NACL (NA), etc.	G-League, minors

Same org brand; different competitive tier. **Advancement** in Alex’s panel = a developmental player **debuts in a top-tier league** within 1–2 years (`top_tier_debut_within_1y` / `_2y`). That is the LoL analog of **NBA draft** or **tenure**.

4. How this maps to the Big Fish / HERO frame

Each row in the panel is roughly: **one player stint** on a **team** in a **league** x **split**, at a **position** (`player_period_id`).

Dissertation term	LoL / CSV
Unit	Player stint in a split
Pond	That team’s roster in that split
Own Â	<code>own_performance_index</code> (composite from match stats)
Peer LOO	<code>teammate_mean_performance_excl_self</code>
Environment	<code>league_tier</code> : <code>developmental</code> <code>top</code> <code>other</code>
Advancement (Y)	<code>top_tier_debut_within_1y</code> or <code>_2y</code>
Censoring	<code>full_1y_followup</code> , <code>full_2y_followup</code> — require before treating False as failure
Analysis cohort	<code>eligible_developmental_cohort</code> — dev-to-pro story still live

Binding split (same as MBB / tenure):

- **Environment** (how strong your teammates / pond are) ≠ **advancement** (whether you get promoted to top tier).
- Performance index **scores** talent; orgs **select** who moves up — score ≠ select.

Cross-domain one-liner

Domain	Pond	Advancement
MBB	College team	NBA draft
Tenure	Department	Tenure
LoL	Dev/academy roster	Top-tier league debut

5. Stats in the panel (why the columns look unfamiliar)

Source: **Oracle’s Elixir** — public match-level data aggregated to stint-level rates.

Stat family	Meaning
Damage / gold / CS per minute	Output and farming
KDA, kill participation	Fight impact
Vision score, wards	Map control (especially jng / sup)
Gold / XP / CS diff @10 / @15	“Did you win lane early?”
Z-scored rates (<code>z_damage_per_min</code> , ...)	Within-stint normalized versions

Roles differ: a support with low damage can still be elite. The panel has team-wide LOO (`teammate_mean_performance_excl_self`) and sparser **same-role** LOO (`same_role_mean_performance_excl_self`).

6. Jargon cheat sheet (CSV-facing)

Term	Meaning
Split	Sub-season (e.g. Spring 2024) — see <code>year</code> , <code>split</code>
League	Competition code (LPL, LCK, LDL, ...) — see <code>league</code>
League tier	Alex mapping: <code>developmental</code> / <code>top</code> / <code>other</code>
Position	<code>top</code> / <code>jng</code> / <code>mid</code> / <code>bot</code> / <code>sup</code>
Promotion / debut	First appearance in a top-tier league — see <code>first_top_tier_*</code> columns

7. Limits to mention honestly

- **Roster churn** — ponds are less stable than a single MBB season.

- **Role heterogeneity** — same composite index across positions is convenient but imperfect.
- **Selection** — promotion is partly org politics and roster needs, not a pure merit sort.
- **Same-role LOO** — only ~27% populated; team LOO is the primary peer context.

Related repo docs

Doc	Path
Column map	<code>datasets/legends/README.md</code>
Active thread	<code>_DISPOSABLE_legends_hero_thread.md</code>
All Big Fish datasets	<code>../_DISPOSABLE_big_fish_datasets_assessment.md</code>

2026-09-03 — COMPASS, for legends sandbox.